



Big shoes to fill: With Kohli and Rohit gone, Shubman Gill and Yashasvi Jaiswal must inherit the legacy of India's top order. AFP

3. At No. 4, Sudharsan has amassed 116 runs in three innings, including a fifty, in the red-ball format.

But Gill reprising the role of opener has its pitfalls. Other than potentially shouldering the burden of captaincy, he also needs to banish the demons of his indifferent record overseas, where he averages 27.53 in 15 matches. His technique against

the new ball has been found wanting, as an average of 32.37 suggests. Ahead of the tour of the West Indies in 2023, Gill had asked to be slotted at No. 3, where he has averaged just under 38 in 17 matches since. Moreover, his struggles in England, where he eked out 88 runs in six innings in the last series, make it incumbent on the management to slot him in at his preferred No. 3 or No. 4 spot.

Opening with Rahul would solve twin problems. In the aftermath of Rohit and Kohli's retirements, the

team needs to cement batting positions for the upcoming World Test Championship (WTC) cycle, and giving Rahul a longer rope in the same position would be a step towards ensuring continuity. After all, he has been an opener for the large part of his stop-start Test career, and has had a fair amount of success opening the innings in England, scoring two hundreds and a fifty while averaging 37.31 across eight games.

Inexperience galore

Amidst all the uncertainty